Chapter One: The Lighthouse Keeper

The fog came in early that autumn, rolling over the harbour like a grey woollen blanket. Elias had kept the lighthouse for thirty-one years, and in all that time he had never seen the sea so quiet. The office below the lamp room smelled of oil, salt and old paper; the first thing he did every morning was to wind the clock and write the date in the logbook.

"You'll catch your death up there," his sister had written in her last letter, "and nobody will find you until spring." He had laughed at that, folded the letter twice and put it under the fluffy grey cat that slept on his desk.

On the twelfth of October a small boat appeared at the edge of the fog. It carried no lights, no flag and, as far as Elias could tell, no crew. He watched it drift closer for an hour before he finally put on his coat and walked down the two hundred and twelve steps to the rocks.

Chapter Two: Über den Nebel

Die Fremde im Boot sprach kaum ein Wort. Sie hieß Jördis, kam angeblich aus Größenwald und trug eine Tasche voller Bücher, deren Seiten nass und schwer waren. „Ich suche jemanden", sagte sie schließlich, „der die Sterne über dem Nebel gezählt hat."

Elias wusste nicht, was er antworten sollte. Er kochte Tee, legte Holz nach und hörte zu, während draußen die Möwen schrien. Später, als das Feuer nur noch glühte, zeigte sie ihm eine Karte: Straßen, Flüsse und Küsten, die es nicht gab, mit kleinen Kreuzen dort, wo früher Leuchttürme gestanden hatten.

"Thirty-one years," she said in careful English, "is a long time to look at the same water." He nodded. It was the truest thing anyone had said to him in a decade.

Chapter Three: The Map

They studied the map until dawn. Every cross was labelled with a name and a year: Kestrel Point 1874, Grey Haven 1902, Saint Aldric 1931. The last entry was written in fresh ink, and it was the name of his own lighthouse, followed by a year that had not yet come.

Elias felt the floor tilt under him, although the sea outside was perfectly still. Efficient, he thought, and affluent, and flawless: the handwriting of someone who had never made a mistake in their life. He folded the map, put it in the drawer with his sister's letters and went up to light the lamp, because whatever the map said, the ships still needed to see the shore.